

Learn HTML: Beginner's Guide

Lesson 3: Working with Text Formatting

Working with Text Formatting – Study Notes

Key Concepts

1. **Basic visual styles** – bold, italic, and underline.
2. **Semantic HTML tags** – `<strong>`, `<em>`, `<mark>` and why they matter.
3. **Difference between presentational and semantic markup.**
4. **Accessibility and SEO benefits of using semantic tags.**
5. **Combining multiple styles safely.**

Summary

Text formatting is one of the first things you'll do when building a web page. The simplest way to change the appearance of text is with **presentational tags** (or CSS classes) such as `<b>`, `<i>`, and `<u>`. While these tags work, they only describe *how* the text looks, not *what* the text means.

Semantic tags—`<strong>`, `<em>`, and `<mark>`—convey meaning to browsers, screen readers, and search engines. `<strong>` indicates importance, `<em>` signals emphasis, and `<mark>` highlights text that is relevant in the current context. Because the meaning is encoded in the markup, browsers can apply default styling (usually bold for `<strong>` and italic for `<em>`), but developers can also override the appearance with CSS while preserving the underlying semantics.

Choosing semantic tags over purely visual ones improves **accessibility** (assistive technologies can announce the importance or emphasis), enhances **SEO** (search engines understand the content hierarchy), and makes your code easier to maintain. You can still use CSS to achieve the exact visual result you want, but the markup should always reflect the intended meaning first.

Important Points

- `<b>` = bold **appearance only**; no semantic meaning.
- `<strong>` = **importance**; default style is bold, but can be restyled with CSS.
- `<i>` = italic **appearance only**; often used for technical terms, foreign words, etc.
- `<em>` = **emphasis**; default style is italic, conveys meaning to assistive tech.
- `<u>` = underline **appearance only**; rarely used because it can be confused with links.
- `<mark>` = **highlight**; indicates text is relevant to the current context (e.g., search results).
- Prefer semantic tags (`<strong>`, `<em>`, `<mark>`) over presentational ones for better accessibility and SEO.
- Use CSS for visual styling; keep HTML focused on structure and meaning.
- Multiple tags can be nested (e.g., `<strong><em>Important and emphasized</em></strong>`).
- Avoid over using `<b>` and `<i>` in modern HTML5; they are kept mainly for legacy content.

Examples

1b ã Basic visual vs. semantic markup

```
```html
<!-- Visual only (presentational) -->
<p>This is bold and <i>italic</i> text.</p>
<!-- Semantic (preferred) -->
<p>This is important and emphasized text.</p>
```
```

Explanation: Both snippets look similar in a browser, but the second version tells the browser that the words are **important** and **emphasized**, which screen readers will announce accordingly.

2b ã Highlighting search terms with `<mark>`

```
```html
<p>Search results for <mark>JavaScript</mark> tutorials:</p>

 Understanding <mark>JavaScript</mark> closures
 Advanced <mark>JavaScript</mark> patterns

```
```

Explanation: `<mark>` visually highlights the term and signals to assistive technology that this portion is relevant to the user's query.

Quick Review

1. **What is the main advantage of using `<strong>` over `<b>`?**
2. **Which tag is used to indicate that a piece of text is highlighted because it matches a user's search?**
3. **True or False:** `<em>` always renders as italic text, but you can change its appearance with CSS.
4. **Name one accessibility benefit of semantic text formatting tags.**
5. **How would you combine emphasis and importance on the same phrase? Provide the HTML.**

Further Reading

- **HTML5 Semantic Elements** – deeper dive into meaning based markup.
- **Accessible Rich Internet Applications (ARIA) – Text Formatting** – how ARIA interacts with semantic tags.
- **CSS Typography** – styling bold, italic, underline, and custom highlights.
- **SEO Best Practices for Content Markup** – why semantics matter for rankings.
